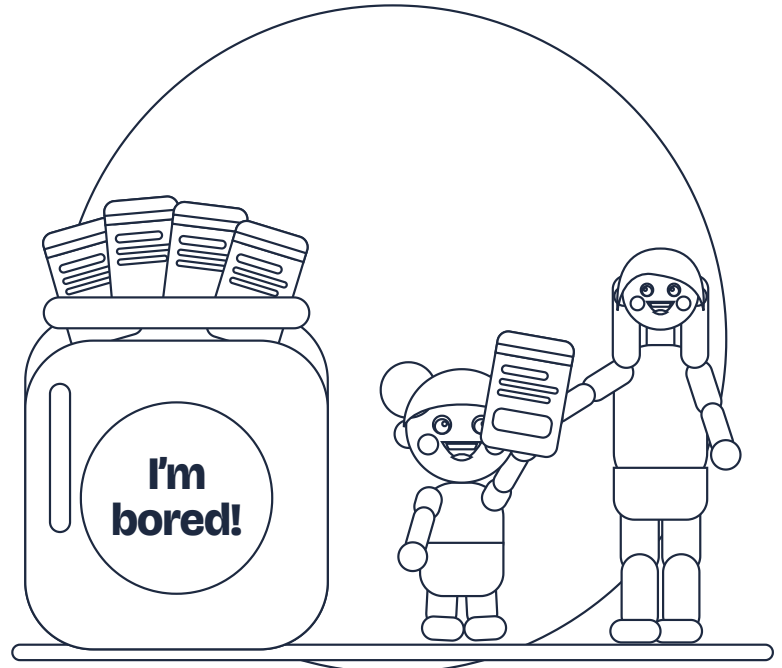


I'm bored! Play Cards

76 screen-free play ideas for ages 1–5, each with what you need, how to play, a talk prompt and a safety note.



76 cards • 2 age bands

Ages 1–5, sorted by age

Calm • Medium • Wiggly

A talk prompt on every card

Prep: about 15 min to print and cut every card with a paper trimmer, then use them again and again. No time? Print one sheet, or point and pick from the card index with no cutting.

Boredom is where play begins.

“I’m bored!” isn’t a problem you have to fix. It’s a pause, and pauses are where children start inventing. These cards give that pause a gentle nudge: one simple idea, the few everyday things you need, and one thing to say while you play.



Talk is built in

Every card has a talk line. The back-and-forth (your question, their answer, your answer back) turns an activity into time together.



Sorted by age and energy

Pick your child’s age band, then ask: calm, medium or wiggly? Matching the mood makes a “yes” more likely.



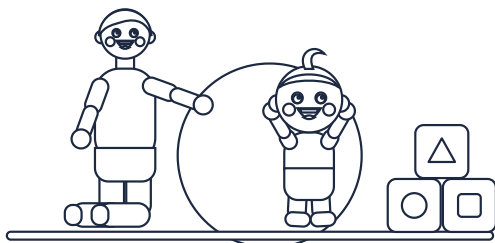
Safety on every card

Every card has its own safety line and follows the rules on page 7. Every card for ages 1–3 uses only things too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.



Made from everyday things

Pots, socks, boxes, paper, a walk outside. 70 of the 76 cards need nothing you have to buy.



WHAT'S INSIDE

76 play cards in 2 age bands: 1–3 and 3–5

14 blank “your idea” cards to write on

20 box dividers: ages, kinds of play, favorites, blanks

12 jar labels, including energy jars and blanks

2 card-back designs for double-sided printing

1 Today’s Play Menu choice board

3 Our Play Week planners: example, Monday and Sunday start

Low-ink edition: white background, line art to color, write-in blanks. The pack comes in color and low-ink files, each in US Letter and A4.

1

Print

Only the sheets you need, at 100% (actual size).

2

Cut & store

About 1 min a sheet with a trimmer. Jar, box or ring.

3

Offer two

Or let your child pull one from the jar.

4

Play & talk

Use the talk line, then follow their lead.

PREP BUDGET

About 15 minutes to print and cut all the cards with a paper trimmer, then they last for years (laminating is optional). **No time today?** Print one sheet, or read titles from the card index on page 21 and let your child pick: no cutting at all.

YOUR JOB AS THE GROWN-UP

You don’t have to entertain. Set out the things on the card, play for the first few minutes, then let your child lead. The grown-up guide on page 3 has the rest.

The grown-up guide

SET UP IN 2 MINUTES

1. Print one sheet for your child's age band (page guide on page 8).
2. Cut it, or skip cutting: point and pick from the card index.
3. Put the cards in a jar, a box or a pocket.
4. Next time you hear "I'm bored!", offer two cards.

WHAT YOUR CHILD IS PRACTICING

- Taking turns and waiting
- Trying an idea and changing it
- Big moves: running, balancing, throwing
- Listening and noticing
- Putting plans and feelings into words
- Finishing something they started

That's all it is: ordinary play. No scores, no levels, nothing to pass.

THREE TALK LINES THAT WORK AT EVERY AGE

1

Pause and wait

Count to five in your head before you jump in. The pause is their turn to talk, point or show you.

2

Say what you see

"You stacked it so tall!" Describe what they are doing instead of asking question after question.

3

Repeat and add one word

They say "truck." You say "big truck!" Their words, plus one more.

WHEN INTEREST FADES

Stop while it's still fun and put the card back for another day. Try the easier version in the card index, or let your child change the rules. Many children lose interest after a few minutes, and that's fine.

Most children love 2-3 of these; that's normal. Playing a favorite again and again is the point.

EVERY LANGUAGE COUNTS

Talk, sign, sing and read in the language you know best. Every language counts.

A sign, a point or a device tap counts as communicating too; answer it as you would words. You don't need to be chatty: reading the talk line word for word, or playing quietly side by side, counts too.

WHEN YOU HEAR "I'M BORED!"

Try: "I hear you. Want to pick one of two cards, or think for a minute first?" Boredom isn't an emergency. A few quiet minutes often turn into your child's own idea, and that counts as a win.

SIBLINGS OF DIFFERENT AGES

Pick a card from the younger child's band and give the older one a job: reader, rule-keeper or helper. Small parts from older cards stay out of reach of children under 3.

Tired grown-up?

Every card has a 2-minute version in the card index (page 21): no setup, played from the couch or the floor. Every play works from a chair, a bed or a wheelchair, and any sound play can be a see-it or feel-it play: flick the light for "stop."

Easier or harder

The card index also gives a "make it easier" and a "make it harder" line for every card, plus the age it usually starts from.

Helping cards are fun

Kitchen & Helping cards are for fun together, never a consequence for saying "I'm bored."

Pantry list & tired-grown-up plays

PANTRY LIST · 25 THINGS MOST HOMES ALREADY HAVE

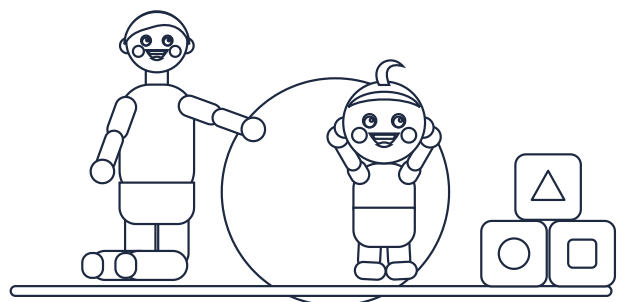
70 of the 76 cards use only everyday things like these (the “Nothing to buy” flag). Keep small things (the ones marked 3+ or 5+) away from children under 3.

- ☐ Big pots and pans
- ☐ Big wooden spoons
- ☐ Plastic cups and bowls
- ☐ Big plastic tubs with lids
- ☐ Towels and dish towels
- ☐ Sheets and blankets
- ☐ Pillows and cushions
- ☐ Cardboard boxes
- ☐ A laundry basket
- ☐ Grown-up socks
- ☐ Soft toys
- ☐ A big soft ball
- ☐ Picture books
- ☐ Paper
- ☐ Palm-size crayons too big for the tube test
- ☐ A flashlight grown-up holds it for under-3s
- ☐ Empty plastic bottles
- ☐ Food boxes from the cupboard
- ☐ Rain boots and a raincoat
- ☐ Pencils and markers ages 3+
- ☐ Painter’s tape ages 3+
- ☐ A deck of cards ages 5+
- ☐ Child-safe scissors ages 5+
- ☐ Sidewalk chalk ages 3+
- ☐ Bubbles grown-up holds the liquid

TIRED-GROWN-UP PLAYS

Played from the couch or the floor, with no setup. Every card’s 2-minute version is in the card index; here are eight to start.

- 1–3 Peekaboo Towel**
Towel over your face on the couch: “Where did I go?”
- 1–3 Knee Bounce Ride**
One rhyme, one bounce, one cuddle.
- 3–5 Animal Charades**
They act, you guess from the couch.
- 3–5 I Spy Colors**
Play from the couch.
- 1–3 Tower and Crash**
Stack three cushions by the couch; they knock them over.
- 1–3 Sink Helper**
Hand them a dry cup and a towel to “wash” beside you.
- 1–3 Picture Walk**
Look at one page together on the couch.
- 3–5 Cushion Fort**
Blanket over two chairs; you sit outside as the guard.



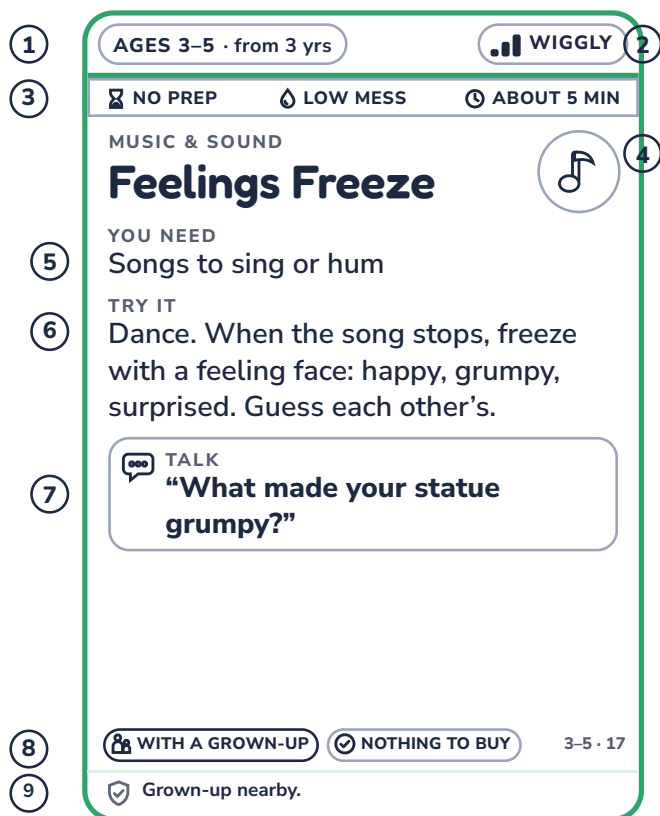
No time to cut?

The card index pages are a no-cut menu: read a few titles aloud and let your child choose, or point to the picture of the kind of play.

Swap freely

No wooden spoon? Any big, sturdy kitchen tool works. Swap what the card asks for with what you have, and keep the card’s safety line.

Read a card in five seconds.



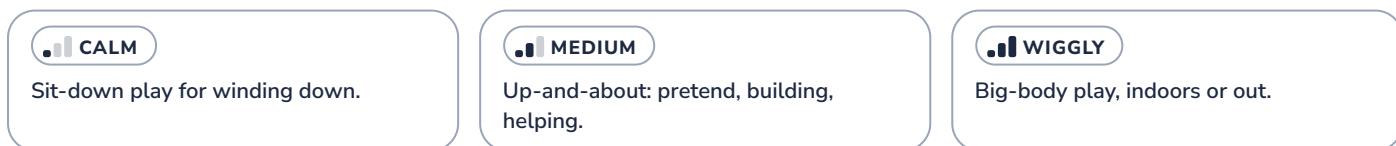
- 1 **Age band and starting age**
Color plus the words, and the age it usually starts from.
- 2 **Energy level**
One, two or three bars: calm, medium or wiggly.
- 3 **Prep, mess, play time**
Setup time, how messy it gets and roughly how long it lasts.
- 4 **Kind of play**
Eight kinds, each with its own picture and divider.
- 5 **You need**
Everyday things. Gather them first.
- 6 **Try it**
One or two short steps. Change anything you like.
- 7 **Talk**
One thing to say or ask while you play, in any language.
- 8 **Who and what**
"With a grown-up" or "Can do alone," plus "Nothing needed" or "Nothing to buy."
- 9 **Safety line**
Read it before you start, every time.

AGE BANDS, ALWAYS WITH A WORD LABEL



Bands overlap on purpose. Children move between them, so try the band above or below whenever a card fits your child.

THREE ENERGY LEVELS



Wiggly cards count toward active play. The World Health Organization's 2019 guidelines recommend at least 180 minutes a day of varied physical activity for children aged 1-4, spread across the day.

EIGHT KINDS OF PLAY



What play looks like at each age.

Every child plays differently, and age bands are a starting point, not a rule. Here is what play often looks like in each band, and the easiest way for a grown-up to join in.

AGES 1–3

Do it again!

PLAY LOOKS LIKE

Filling and dumping, stacking and knocking down, copying you, again and again.

YOUR PART

Be the partner on the floor. Keep turns short, and repeat whatever gets a smile.



TALK TIP

Short words and long pauses. Say what they're doing ("In! Out!"), then wait for any sound, sign or point back.

THREE TO TRY FIRST

Tower and Crash

Sink Helper

Picture Walk

AGES 3–5

Let's pretend

PLAY LOOKS LIKE

Pretend worlds, chasing games, simple rules, and stories that change every minute.

YOUR PART

Take a part in the story (customer, patient, passenger) and let your child direct.



TALK TIP

Ask "what happens next?" and add one new word to what they say.

THREE TO TRY FIRST

Cushion Fort

Pretend Café

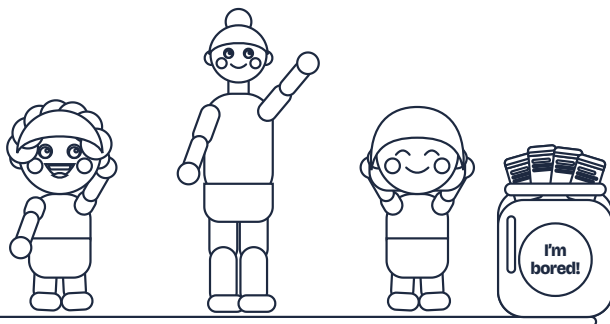
Feelings Freeze

BETWEEN TWO BANDS?

Children move between bands all the time. Play a 3–5 card with a two-year-old and be the helper, or bring back a 1–3 favorite for a four-year-old. The card index gives an easier and a harder way for every card.

BIG BROTHERS AND SISTERS

An older child can join any card as the reader, the rule-keeper or the helper. Keep small things from their games away from children under 3.



Every child plays and talks on their own timeline. If you have questions about your child's development, talk with your pediatrician.

Safety first, then fun.

Every play follows these safety rules, and every card has its own safety line at the bottom. They apply to every card, including the ones you write yourself.



A grown-up is always in charge

Every card assumes an adult nearby. For ages 1–3, stay within reach the whole time. Every card for under-5s says “With a grown-up.”



Water

Any amount of water means a grown-up within arm’s reach, the whole time. Empty tubs and buckets straight after play.



Cords, strings and scarves

Nothing long enough to wrap around a neck: no long strings, cords, ties or long scarves. Sheets and blankets are draped, never tied.



Outdoors

Play well away from the street. No berries or mushrooms. Hats, water and shade in the sun. No puddle play in thunder or lightning.



Small parts and under-3s

For children under 3, use only things too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm across). Every 1–3 card is written this way. Older cards that use small things (coins, dice, tape, seeds, dough) say so: keep those away from younger brothers and sisters.



No balloons

Balloons are not safe for children under 8, so no card in this pack uses them.



Food and the kitchen

Sit down to eat. No whole grapes, nuts, popcorn, hard candy or marshmallows for young children; cut food thin and soft. Check allergies. Grown-ups handle sharp knives, the stove and the oven.



Hide-and-seek

Never hide in appliances, chests, trunks or cars.



Too big to fit: OK



Fits: too small



THE TOILET-PAPER TUBE TEST

If it fits through the tube, it’s too small for under-3s.

Keep a cardboard tube in the play basket and test anything new before a toddler plays with it. A tube is about 1.25 in (3.2 cm) across.

The cards and pieces

Grown-up keeps the cut pieces and the jar. Every cut piece in this pack is 1.5 in or larger. Printed cards are paper, not toys for children who still mouth things: round laminated corners. Hook-and-loop dots: check them before each play; remove any that lift. No loose dots for under-3s.

You know your child best

Skip or change any card that doesn’t suit your child, your space or your day. These cards are ideas for play at home. They are not medical or developmental advice.

Make them last.

- 1 Print**
 Print at 100% or “actual size,” not “fit to page.” Cardstock (65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm) makes sturdy cards. Pick the US Letter or A4 file to match your paper.
- 2 Double-sided (optional)**
 Print the backs page for your age band once for each card sheet. Put the printed stack back in the tray (test one sheet first to see which way it goes) and print the fronts on the other side.
- 3 Cut**
 Straight lines only: 4 cuts each way per sheet with a paper trimmer or scissors. The white border inside each card hides small wobbles. Grown-up keeps the pieces.
- 4 Laminate**
 Pouches (3–5 mil) make cards last for years and wipe clean. Leave a thin sealed edge, then round the corners so there are no sharp points.
- 5 Hook-and-loop dots**
 For the Play Menu (ages 3+): a hook dot on each card back, loop dots on the board. Check dots before each play; remove any that lift. Store spare dots out of reach: they’re small parts.
- 6 Store**
 A big jar with one of the labels, a 3 × 5 in recipe box with the dividers, or a binder ring through a punched corner. Keep rings away from little ones.

PAGE GUIDE · PRINT ONLY WHAT YOU NEED

Start here	2
Grown-up guide & pantry list	3–4
How to read a card · play at every age	5–6
Safety rules	7
Print, cut, laminate & store	8
Ages 1–3 cards	9–13
Ages 3–5 cards	14–18
Card backs (optional)	19–20
Card index & grown-up companion	21–23
Box dividers	24–27
Jar labels	28–29
Play Menu + weekly planners	30–33
Play Jar Star certificate	34
Quick answers	35
More from us · license	36

HANDY SUPPLIES

- ☆ Cardstock, 65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm
- ☆ A paper trimmer or scissors
- ☆ Laminator and 3–5 mil pouches (optional)
- ☆ Corner rounder (optional)
- ☆ Hook-and-loop dots (optional, ages 3+)
- ☆ A big jar or a 3 × 5 in recipe box

You have the low-ink file: white backgrounds and line art your child can color in.

SIX WAYS TO PLAY WITH THE CARDS

The jar pull

Your child pulls a card. Don’t like it? Put it back and pull once more.

Pick one of two

Lay out two cards and let your child choose. Choosing is half the fun.

Energy check

Ask “calm, medium or wiggly?” first, then pull from that energy.

Play Menu

Put four cards on the menu in the morning: calm, wiggly, together and free choice.

Big helper

An older child reads a 1–3 card aloud and plays it with a younger one, with a grown-up close by.

Move up a band

When the 1–3 cards feel easy, mix in a few 3–5 cards. Keep the under-3 size rule for little siblings.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

WIGGLY

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MUSIC & SOUND

Pot-and-Spoon Band

YOU NEED

2 big pots, 2 big wooden spoons

TRY IT

Turn the pots upside down. Drum loud, then soft, then fast, then slow. Take turns copying each other's beat.

TALK

"Loud or quiet? Your turn!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 01

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

PRETEND

Box Car Ride

YOU NEED

A big cardboard box

TRY IT

Your child sits in the box. Push it slowly around the room and stop at "stations" to wave hello.

TALK

"Where should we go? Ready... go!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 02

Push slowly; the box stays on the floor.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Peekaboo Towel

YOU NEED

A dish towel

TRY IT

Hide your face, then a big toy, then your child's foot under the towel. Pause before every "boo!"

TALK

"Where's your foot? There it is!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 03

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Tower and Crash

YOU NEED

Big blocks or empty cereal boxes

TRY IT

Stack them up together and count "one, two, three." Then your child knocks it down. Again!

TALK

"Up, up, up... crash!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 04

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MOVE

Roll It Back

YOU NEED

A large soft ball

TRY IT

Sit facing each other with legs apart. Roll the ball back and forth. Then roll it under a chair "tunnel."

TALK

"Ready, set... roll!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 05

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

SOME MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

KITCHEN & HELPING

Sink Helper

YOU NEED

A tub of shallow water, big plastic cups, a towel

TRY IT

Set the tub on a towel on the floor. Fill, pour and "wash" the cups together.

TALK

"Full or empty? Pour it out!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 06

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time.

AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

KITCHEN & HELPING

Sock Match

YOU NEED

A basket of clean grown-up socks

TRY IT

Pull out one sock at a time. Find its partner together and toss each pair in the basket.

TALK

"Same? Not the same?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 07

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 15 mo

WIGGLY

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MOVE

Animal Parade

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Stomp like an elephant, hop like a bunny, waddle like a duck. Follow the leader, then swap.

TALK

"Quack, quack! Your turn, duck."

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

1-3 · 08

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

WORDS & STORIES

Mirror Faces

YOU NEED

Just your faces

TRY IT

Sit face to face, or side by side at a mirror. Make a happy, sleepy or surprised face. Copy each other.

TALK

"You look surprised! Oh!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 09

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

PRETEND

Basket Boat

YOU NEED

A laundry basket, pillows

TRY IT

Your child sits in the basket “boat.” Rock it gently and sing a boat song. Pillows are islands.

TALK

“Row, row... what comes next?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 10

Basket stays on the floor; stay right beside it.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Treasure Box

YOU NEED

A box, 5 big things (a cup, a grown-up sock, a big spoon)

TRY IT

Put the things in a box. Your child pulls one out. Name it together and show what it does.

TALK

“What’s this? A cup! We drink!”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 11

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 15 mo

WIGGLY

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

MOVE

Pillow Mountain

YOU NEED

Couch cushions and pillows

TRY IT

Pile cushions low on the floor. Climb up, roll down and crawl through.

TALK

“Up the mountain... and down!”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 12

Keep it low and soft, away from furniture corners.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

WIGGLY

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

OUTDOORS

Bubble Chase

YOU NEED

Bubbles

TRY IT

Blow bubbles outside. Your child chases and pops them. Wait a moment before you blow the next ones.

TALK

“More bubbles? More!”

WITH A GROWN-UP

1-3 · 13

Grown-up holds the bubble liquid.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

PRETEND

Sock Friend Hello

YOU NEED

A clean sock

TRY IT

Put the sock on your hand. Your sock friend says hi, sneezes and gets sleepy. Your child feeds it pretend food.

TALK

“Sock friend is hungry! Yum, yum!”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 14

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 24 mo

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Color Hunt

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Pick a color. Walk around the house and touch everything that color. Then pick a new one.

TALK

“Red! Where’s more red?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

1-3 · 15

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 15 mo

WIGGLY

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MUSIC & SOUND

Stop-and-Go Dance

YOU NEED

A song you can sing

TRY IT

Sing and dance together. Stop singing and freeze like statues. Start again!

TALK

“Stop! ... Go!”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 16

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

WORDS & STORIES

Picture Walk

YOU NEED

A favorite picture book

TRY IT

Skip the words. Point to the pictures and say what you see. Wait for your child to point too.

TALK

“I see a dog. What do you see?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 17

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Cups and Bowls

YOU NEED

Nesting bowls or plastic tubs, a big toy

TRY IT

Nest them, stack them, then hide the toy under one and slide them around slowly.

TALK

“Which one? Under here?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 18

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

© GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES · EVERY PIECE IS 1.5 IN OR LARGER · © 2026 ALPHAPLAY LLC. PLAY BEFORE PIXELS IS A TRADE NAME OF ALPHAPLAY LLC.

AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo MEDIUM PREP 2 MIN · SOME MESS · ABOUT 10 MIN OUTDOORS Paint with Water YOU NEED A wide paintbrush (wider than the tube), a cup of water TRY IT Paint the fence or the steps with plain water. Watch the pictures disappear. TALK "Where did it go? Paint it again!" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 19 Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time.	AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo CALM PREP 2 MIN · LOW MESS · ABOUT 10 MIN PRETEND Teddy Picnic YOU NEED Soft toys, a blanket, plastic cups and plates TRY IT Spread the blanket and set a place for each toy. Pretend to pour, share and say "yum." TALK "Teddy wants more. More tea?" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 20 Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.	AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo WIGGLY PREP 2 MIN · LOW MESS · ABOUT 10 MIN MOVE Sheet Tunnel YOU NEED A sheet, 2 chairs TRY IT Drape the sheet over the chairs to make a tunnel. Crawl through and peek out the end. TALK "Where are you? Peekaboo!" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 21 Drape the sheet loose; never tie it. Stay close.
AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo CALM NO PREP · LOW MESS · ABOUT 5 MIN KITCHEN & HELPING Wipe the Table YOU NEED A damp cloth TRY IT After a meal, give your child a cloth. Wipe in circles, then back and forth. Sing while you wipe. TALK "Wipe, wipe... all clean!" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 22 Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.	AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo CALM PREP 2 MIN · SOME MESS · ABOUT 10 MIN OUTDOORS Nature Basket YOU NEED A basket, a walk TRY IT Collect big things: large leaves and big pinecones. Sort them at home: big, bigger, biggest. TALK "Big leaf! Crunchy leaf!" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 23 Only items bigger than a toilet-paper tube. No berries or mushrooms.	AGES 1-3 · from 15 mo MEDIUM PREP 2 MIN · LOW MESS · ABOUT 5 MIN BUILD & MAKE Car Ramp YOU NEED A couch cushion, a big toy car TRY IT Lean a cushion on the couch to make a ramp. Roll the car down. Make the ramp steeper. TALK "Ready, set... go!" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 24 Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.
AGES 1-3 · from 15 mo CALM NO PREP · LOW MESS · ABOUT 5 MIN PRETEND Pretend Phone Call YOU NEED A big block or a banana as the "phone" TRY IT Pretend to call Grandma. Say hi, wait, then answer. Hand the "phone" to your child. TALK "Hello? Who is it?" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 25 Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.	AGES 1-3 · from 15 mo CALM PREP 2 MIN · SOME MESS · ABOUT 10 MIN BUILD & MAKE Big Paper Scribble YOU NEED A big sheet of paper, palm-size toddler crayons TRY IT Draw together: zig-zags, round and round, dot-dot-dot. Name what you make. TALK "Round and round... a ball!" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 26 Crayons too big for the tube test; take away broken bits. Grown-up puts them away.	AGES 1-3 · from 24 mo WIGGLY PREP 2 MIN · LOW MESS · ABOUT 5 MIN MOVE Pillow Hop YOU NEED 3-4 flat pillows TRY IT Lay the pillows in a line on a rug. Step or jump from one to the next like stepping stones. TALK "Jump! One more?" WITH A GROWN-UP · NOTHING TO BUY · 1-3 · 27 On a rug, away from sharp corners.

AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MUSIC & SOUND

Fill-In Songs

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Sing a song with actions you both know. Stop before a word and wait for your child to fill it in.

TALK

"The wheels on the bus go...?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

1-3 · 28

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MUSIC & SOUND

What's That Sound?

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Sit very still and listen. A car? A bird? The fridge? Point to where each sound comes from.

TALK

"Shh... what's that sound?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

1-3 · 29

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

OUTDOORS

Point-and-Name Walk

YOU NEED

A walk outside

TRY IT

Walk slowly. Stop at anything your child looks at and name it: dog, truck, flower.

TALK

"You see the truck! Big truck."

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 30

Hold hands near roads and driveways.

AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Lid Match

YOU NEED

3 light pots or tubs with lids

TRY IT

Take all the lids off. Your child finds which lid fits which pot.

TALK

"Does it fit? Try another!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 31

Light pots only, far from the stove.

AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

PRETEND

Teddy Bedtime

YOU NEED

A soft toy, a small towel

TRY IT

Put teddy to bed: bath, brush teeth, story, song. Let your child lead every step.

TALK

"What does teddy need now?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 32

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 15 mo

WIGGLY

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

MOVE

Delivery Push

YOU NEED

A laundry basket, soft toys

TRY IT

Your child pushes the basket across the room to deliver soft toys to each person.

TALK

"Push, push... a delivery for you!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 33

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Where's Teddy?

YOU NEED

A big soft toy

TRY IT

Hide teddy half in view while your child watches. Next time, hide him a little more. Cheer every find.

TALK

"Is he under the chair?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 34

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 15 mo

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

KITCHEN & HELPING

Tidy-Up Toss

YOU NEED

A basket, soft toys

TRY IT

Sing a tidy song and toss soft toys into the basket. Count them as they go in.

TALK

"One, two... in it goes!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 35

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 18 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Hand Shadows

YOU NEED

A flashlight (grown-up holds it)

TRY IT

In a dim room, make shadow shapes on the wall: a bird, a dog. Help your child make one.

TALK

"Look, a bird! Flap, flap!"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 36

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MUSIC & SOUND

Knee Bounce Ride

YOU NEED

Your lap

TRY IT

Bounce your child gently on your knees to a rhyme: slow, then bumpy, then a gentle “whoops!”

TALK

“Again? Again!”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 37

Gentle bounces; hold your child securely.

AGES 1-3 · from 12 mo

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Fill and Dump

YOU NEED

A big bowl, big blocks or rolled-up socks

TRY IT

Fill the bowl, dump it out, fill it again. Count as things go in.

TALK

“In... in... out!”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

1-3 · 38

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

AGES 1-3

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

FROM

PREP

TIME

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

WITH A GROWN-UP

CAN DO ALONE

Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.

AGES 1-3

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

FROM

PREP

TIME

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

WITH A GROWN-UP

CAN DO ALONE

Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.

AGES 1-3

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

FROM

PREP

TIME

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

WITH A GROWN-UP

CAN DO ALONE

Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.

AGES 1-3

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

FROM

PREP

TIME

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

WITH A GROWN-UP

CAN DO ALONE

Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.

AGES 1-3

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

FROM

PREP

TIME

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

WITH A GROWN-UP

CAN DO ALONE

Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.

AGES 1-3

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

FROM

PREP

TIME

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

WITH A GROWN-UP

CAN DO ALONE

Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.

AGES 1-3

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

FROM

PREP

TIME

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

WITH A GROWN-UP

CAN DO ALONE

Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Cushion Fort

YOU NEED

Cushions, a sheet, chairs, books

TRY IT

Build a fort together. Add a door, a sign and a pile of books inside.

TALK

“Who’s allowed in? What’s the password?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 01

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

WIGGLY

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

MOVE

The Floor Is Lava

YOU NEED

Pillows, a rug

TRY IT

Scatter pillows on the floor. Cross the room without touching the “lava.”

TALK

“Which pillow is safest? Why?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 02

Soft floor only; move sharp-cornered furniture.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

PRETEND

Pretend Café

YOU NEED

Plastic dishes, paper, crayons

TRY IT

Your child runs a café. Draw a picture menu. You order; they cook and serve.

TALK

“What do you recommend today?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 03

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

KITCHEN & HELPING

Laundry Sort

YOU NEED

A basket of clean clothes

TRY IT

Sort clothes by color, then by who owns them. Fold washcloths together.

TALK

“Whose sock is this? How do you know?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 04

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 4 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 10 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Picture-Clue Hunt

YOU NEED

A toy “treasure,” paper, crayon

TRY IT

Draw 3-5 picture clues (the bed, the fridge). Each clue leads to the next. Treasure at the end!

TALK

“Where does this picture tell us to go?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 05

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 10 MIN

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Tape Road

YOU NEED

Painter’s tape, toy cars

TRY IT

Tape a road on the floor with turns, a bridge and a parking lot. Drive the cars along it.

TALK

“Where is your car going next?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

3-5 · 06

Keep small pieces away from children under 3.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

WIGGLY

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Simon Says

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Play Simon Says with big moves: touch your toes, spin, hop. Then your child is Simon.

TALK

“Simon says... what should we do?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

3-5 · 07

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

OUTDOORS

Feel-It Hunt

YOU NEED

A paper bag or basket, a walk

TRY IT

Find something smooth, something bumpy, something green and something that smells nice.

TALK

“How does it feel? What is it like?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 08

Look, don’t eat: no berries or mushrooms.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

WORDS & STORIES

Story in a Bag

YOU NEED

A cloth or paper bag, 4 household things

TRY IT

Pull out one thing at a time and add it to a story together. “Once upon a time, a spoon...”

TALK

“And then what happened?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 09

Grown-up nearby.

© GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES · EVERY PIECE IS 1.5 IN OR LARGER · © 2026 ALPHAPLAY LLC. PLAY BEFORE PIXELS IS A TRADE NAME OF ALPHAPLAY LLC.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

MESSY

20+ MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Dough Bakery

YOU NEED

Play dough, cookie cutters, a rolling pin

TRY IT

Roll, cut and “bake” dough cookies. Set up a counter and sell them.

TALK

“How many cookies? Which shape?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

3-5 · 10

Keep dough away from children under 3.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

WIGGLY

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Animal Charades

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Take turns acting out an animal without sounds. Guess it. Then add the sound.

TALK

“What clues did you see?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

3-5 · 11

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3½ yrs

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

WORDS & STORIES

Rhyme Basket

YOU NEED

Things around the house

TRY IT

Find things that rhyme: sock-clock, cat-hat, spoon-moon. Silly made-up words count!

TALK

“What rhymes with ‘bed’?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 12

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

SOME MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

KITCHEN & HELPING

Veggie Scrub

YOU NEED

A bowl of water, a brush, potatoes or carrots

TRY IT

Scrub the veggies clean. Count them, then line them up from biggest to smallest.

TALK

“Which is the biggest? The muddiest?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 13

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

WIGGLY

PREP 10 MIN

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

MOVE

Obstacle Course

YOU NEED

Pillows, a chair, a blanket

TRY IT

Build a course: crawl under, step over, hop around, touch the wall, run back.

TALK

“What should we add? First... then...”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 14

Clear the space; keep it low.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

PRETEND

Toy Vet

YOU NEED

Soft toys, a few short cloth strips or tissues

TRY IT

Your child is the vet. Toys come in with an “ouchie.” Check, wrap and give a hug.

TALK

“What happened to Bunny? How can we help?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 15

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

SOME MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Sink or Float

YOU NEED

A tub of water, a spoon, a sponge, an apple, a lid

TRY IT

Guess first, then drop each thing in. Sort them into “sink” and “float.”

TALK

“What do you think will happen? Why?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 16

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

WIGGLY

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MUSIC & SOUND

Feelings Freeze

YOU NEED

Songs to sing or hum

TRY IT

Dance. When the song stops, freeze with a feeling face: happy, grumpy, surprised. Guess each other's.

TALK

“What made your statue grumpy?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 17

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Book Bridge

YOU NEED

Blocks, books, a toy car

TRY IT

Build a bridge between two piles of books. Test it with a car. Can it hold two?

TALK

“What makes it strong?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 18

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

I Spy Colors

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Say “I spy something... blue!” Take turns. Then try shapes: “something round.”

TALK

“Is it big or small? Give me a clue.”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

3-5 · 19

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

PREP 10 MIN

SOME MESS

20+ MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Paper-Plate Masks

YOU NEED

Paper plates, crayons

TRY IT

A grown-up cuts eye holes. Your child colors a lion, a cat or a hero. Hold it up and act it out.

TALK

“Who are you? What can you do?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 20

Grown-up cuts. Hold masks by hand; no strings.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

WIGGLY

PREP 2 MIN

SOME MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

OUTDOORS

Chalk Hop Path

YOU NEED

Sidewalk chalk

TRY IT

Draw a path of squares, circles and spirals. Hop, jump and spin through it.

TALK

“Which square is trickiest?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

3-5 · 21

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

WORDS & STORIES

Couch Puppet Show

YOU NEED

Socks or paper bags, a couch

TRY IT

Make two puppets. Put on a show from behind the couch. The grown-up is the audience.

TALK

“What’s the problem in your show?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 22

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

PRETEND

Corner Shop

YOU NEED

Food boxes from the cupboard, a basket

TRY IT

Set up a shop. Your child is the shopkeeper. Draw paper money to pay.

TALK

“How much is that? Do you have apples?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 23

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

PRETEND

Mail Carrier

YOU NEED

Folded paper, crayons, a basket or paper bag

TRY IT

Draw pictures and “mail” them to people and toys around the house. Knock and deliver.

TALK

“Who is this for? What does it say?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 24

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

OUTDOORS

Bug Watch

YOU NEED

A magnifying glass if you have one

TRY IT

Gently lift leaves with a grown-up. Watch bugs, count their legs, then leave them be.

TALK

“Where is it going? How many legs?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 25

Look, don’t touch. Wash hands after.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

MUSIC & SOUND

Kitchen Band

YOU NEED

Pots, a whisk, a sealed plastic shaker

TRY IT

Make a band from kitchen things. One plays fast, one plays slow. Swap instruments.

TALK

“Which one sounds like rain?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 26

Keep small pieces away from children under 3.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

OUTDOORS

Listening Walk

YOU NEED

A walk, paper, crayons

TRY IT

Go outside and count the sounds you hear: birds, cars, wind. Draw them at home.

TALK

“Which sound was the loudest?”

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 27

Hold hands near roads.

AGES 3-5 · from 3½ yrs

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

WORDS & STORIES

Opposites Game

YOU NEED
Nothing

TRY IT
Act out one side of an opposite: big, fast, up. Your child acts out the other side.

TALK
"If I'm tall, you're...?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

3-5 · 28

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

MOVE

Tape Balance Beam

YOU NEED
Painter's tape, a soft toy

TRY IT
Put a tape line on the floor. Walk it forward, backward, on tiptoes, with a toy on your head.

TALK
"Can you walk it like a crab?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

3-5 · 29

Keep small pieces away from children under 3.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

MESSY

20+ MIN

BUILD & MAKE

Color Mixing

YOU NEED
Washable paint, paper, a brush

TRY IT
Mix two colors and see what appears. Paint a rainbow with your new colors.

TALK
"What happens if we add yellow?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

3-5 · 30

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

WIGGLY

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Red Light, Green Light

YOU NEED
Nothing

TRY IT
"Green light" means move, "red light" means freeze, "yellow light" means slow motion. Swap callers.

TALK
"What other lights could we invent?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING NEEDED

3-5 · 31

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 4 yrs

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

20+ MIN

WORDS & STORIES

Make a Little Book

YOU NEED
3 sheets of paper folded in half, crayons

TRY IT
Fold a little book. Your child draws a picture on each page; you write down their words.

TALK
"What happens on this page?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 32

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

WIGGLY

PREP 2 MIN

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

PRETEND

Rescue Mission

YOU NEED
Soft toys, a blanket

TRY IT
Toys are stuck on the couch "island." Your child rescues each one and brings it to safe base.

TALK
"Who needs help? How will you get there?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 33

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

PREP 2 MIN

SOME MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

KITCHEN & HELPING

Snack Patterns

YOU NEED
Crackers, thin cheese slices, soft banana slices

TRY IT
Make a pattern on a plate: cracker, cheese, cracker, cheese. What comes next? Then eat it.

TALK
"How did you know what comes next?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 34

Sit to eat. Thin, soft pieces for little ones; check allergies.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

MEDIUM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 10 MIN

GAMES & PUZZLES

Sock Ball Toss

YOU NEED
Rolled-up socks, a laundry basket

TRY IT
Toss sock balls into the basket. Take a step back after every goal. Keep score with tally marks.

TALK
"How many went in? What helped?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 35

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3 yrs

CALM

NO PREP

LOW MESS

ABOUT 5 MIN

MOVE

Animal Stretches

YOU NEED
A rug or towel

TRY IT
Stretch like a cat, stand like a flamingo, curl up like a mouse. Breathe slowly between each.

TALK
"Which animal feels the calmest?"

WITH A GROWN-UP

NOTHING TO BUY

3-5 · 36

Grown-up nearby.

AGES 3-5 · from 3½ yrs CALM NO PREP LOW MESS ABOUT 10 MIN WORDS & STORIES Flashlight Stories YOU NEED A flashlight, a dim room TRY IT Make hand shadows on the wall and tell a short story with them. TALK “What does the shadow bird want?” WITH A GROWN-UP NOTHING TO BUY 3-5 · 37 Grown-up nearby.	AGES 3-5 · from 3½ yrs MEDIUM PREP 2 MIN SOME MESS 20+ MIN OUTDOORS Build a Nest YOU NEED Sticks, leaves, grass, a soft toy TRY IT Gather sticks and leaves outside. Build a nest big enough for a soft-toy bird. TALK “What would a bird need in its nest?” WITH A GROWN-UP NOTHING TO BUY 3-5 · 38 Play in the yard or park, well away from the street.	AGES 3-5 CALM MED WIGGLY FROM PREP TIME YOUR IDEA YOU NEED TRY IT TALK WITH A GROWN-UP CAN DO ALONE Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.
AGES 3-5 CALM MED WIGGLY FROM PREP TIME YOUR IDEA YOU NEED TRY IT TALK WITH A GROWN-UP CAN DO ALONE Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.	AGES 3-5 CALM MED WIGGLY FROM PREP TIME YOUR IDEA YOU NEED TRY IT TALK WITH A GROWN-UP CAN DO ALONE Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.	AGES 3-5 CALM MED WIGGLY FROM PREP TIME YOUR IDEA YOU NEED TRY IT TALK WITH A GROWN-UP CAN DO ALONE Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.
AGES 3-5 CALM MED WIGGLY FROM PREP TIME YOUR IDEA YOU NEED TRY IT TALK WITH A GROWN-UP CAN DO ALONE Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.	AGES 3-5 CALM MED WIGGLY FROM PREP TIME YOUR IDEA YOU NEED TRY IT TALK WITH A GROWN-UP CAN DO ALONE Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.	AGES 3-5 CALM MED WIGGLY FROM PREP TIME YOUR IDEA YOU NEED TRY IT TALK WITH A GROWN-UP CAN DO ALONE Our safety rules apply to your cards too: see the safety page.





Tick a box when you've played a card. Each card's safety line applies to all its versions.







 = kind of play · bars = energy · No time to cut? Read titles aloud and let your child pick.

CARD · STARTING AGE	MAKE IT EASIER	MAKE IT HARDER	2-MINUTE TIRED-GROWN-UP VERSION
Ages 1–3			38 CARDS
☐ 01 Pot-and-Spoon Band  from 12 mo	Drum one pot together, hand over hand.	Copy a 3-beat pattern: loud, soft, loud.	Drum on your knees; they copy you.
☐ 02 Box Car Ride  from 12 mo	Sit in the box together and rock it gently.	Hand over a paper ticket at each station.	Sit them in the box and make car sounds together.
☐ 03 Peekaboo Towel  from 12 mo	Hide only your own face, again and again.	They hide a big toy for you to find.	Towel over your face on the couch: "Where did I go?"
☐ 04 Tower and Crash  from 12 mo	Stack just two, then crash.	Build it as tall as they are, then count down.	Stack three cushions by the couch; they knock them over.
☐ 05 Roll It Back  from 12 mo	Sit close and roll it a short way.	Roll it to knock over an empty cereal-box "pin."	Lie on the floor and roll it back and forth.
☐ 06 Sink Helper  from 18 mo	Pour from one cup into the tub, together.	Fill each cup to a line you point to.	Hand them a dry cup and a towel to "wash" beside you.
☐ 07 Sock Match  from 18 mo	Find one pair among three socks.	Sort into big socks and small socks.	Pass socks one by one; they drop them in the basket.
☐ 08 Animal Parade  from 15 mo	Stomp like an elephant, together.	Add a quiet animal and a loud one.	Name an animal from the couch; they act it out.
☐ 09 Mirror Faces  from 12 mo	Just smile, then open your mouth wide. Side by side is fine.	Make a face; they say or sign the feeling.	Copy every face they make, right where you sit.
☐ 10 Basket Boat  from 12 mo	Rock the basket gently while you sing.	Go "fishing" for soft toys from the boat.	Sing a boat song while they sit in the basket beside you.
☐ 11 Treasure Box  from 12 mo	Use two things instead of five.	Ask "what do we do with it?" and wait.	Hand them one big thing at a time from your seat.
☐ 12 Pillow Mountain  from 15 mo	One pillow to climb over.	Add a cushion "cave" to crawl through.	Lie on the rug: you are the mountain they climb.
☐ 13 Bubble Chase  from 12 mo	Blow a few slow bubbles low down to pop.	They say or sign "more" before each blow.	Blow bubbles from the doorstep or the couch.
☐ 14 Sock Friend Hello  from 12 mo	The sock friend just says hi and waves.	Your child wears the sock friend and talks to you.	Sock friend on your hand, you on the couch: it asks their name.
☐ 15 Color Hunt  from 24 mo	Hold up something red; find one more.	Find three things of one color and line them up.	From your seat: "Bring me something... blue!"
☐ 16 Stop-and-Go Dance  from 15 mo	Hold hands and freeze together. Or flick the light for stop.	Freeze in a shape: tall, small or wide.	Sing and clap from your seat; they freeze when you stop.
☐ 17 Picture Walk  from 12 mo	Point to one picture per page.	Ask "where is the...?" and wait for a point.	Look at one page together on the couch.
☐ 18 Cups and Bowls  from 12 mo	Nest just two bowls.	Hide the toy under one of three and slide slowly.	Stack bowls on the floor next to you.
☐ 19 Paint with Water  from 18 mo	Paint with a wet hand instead of a brush.	Paint a big shape, then watch it vanish.	Sit on the step beside them while they paint it.
☐ 20 Teddy Picnic  from 18 mo	Feed teddy one pretend bite.	Plan the menu: "What does teddy want?"	Hand them a cup: "Teddy's thirsty!"
☐ 21 Sheet Tunnel  from 12 mo	Hold the sheet up like a tent and peek.	Crawl through carrying a toy to deliver.	Drape a sheet over your knees: a tiny tent.
☐ 22 Wipe the Table  from 18 mo	Wipe one spot together.	Wipe, then dry with a second cloth.	Hand them a cloth for the chair next to you.
☐ 23 Nature Basket  from 18 mo	Collect only big leaves.	Line them up: big, bigger, biggest.	Look out of a window and name what you see.
☐ 24 Car Ramp  from 15 mo	Roll the car along a flat cushion.	Try two ramps: which is faster?	Use your legs as the ramp on the couch.
☐ 25 Pretend Phone Call  from 15 mo	Say "hello" and "bye-bye" back and forth.	Call a toy and pass on a message.	"Ring ring!" from the couch; they answer.
☐ 26 Big Paper Scribble  from 15 mo	Just dots: dot, dot, dot.	Draw a circle; they add the eyes.	Doodle side by side on scrap paper at the table.
☐ 27 Pillow Hop  from 24 mo	Step, don't jump, holding your hand.	Add a pillow "river" to hop over.	One pillow on the rug: hop on, hop off.

Tick a box when you've played a card. Each card's safety line applies to all its versions.

        = kind of play · bars = energy · No time to cut? Read titles aloud and let your child pick.

	CARD · STARTING AGE	MAKE IT EASIER	MAKE IT HARDER	2-MINUTE TIRED-GROWN-UP VERSION
☐ 28	Fill-In Songs  from 18 mo	Stop only on the very last word.	Stop earlier in the line and wait longer.	Sing from the couch and pause for their word.
☐ 29	What's That Sound?  from 12 mo	Listen for one sound: "A car!" Or feel one: a hand on the humming fridge.	Guess a sound you make behind your back.	Close your eyes together and just listen.
☐ 30	Point-and-Name Walk  from 12 mo	Name three things, then head home.	Add one word: "big truck," "red truck."	Stand at the window and name what goes by.
☐ 31	Lid Match  from 18 mo	One pot and one lid.	Four pots, plus a lid that fits none.	Hand them two tubs and lids at your feet.
☐ 32	Teddy Bedtime  from 18 mo	Just tuck teddy in with a blanket.	Teddy won't sleep! How can we help?	Lie down and let them tuck you and teddy in.
☐ 33	Delivery Push  from 15 mo	Push the basket to one person.	Take orders: "A bear for me, please."	Ask for a delivery to the couch.
☐ 34	Where's Teddy?  from 12 mo	Hide teddy under a blanket in full view.	Hide teddy in the next room.	Hide teddy behind your back.
☐ 35	Tidy-Up Toss  from 15 mo	Drop toys in; no tossing.	Take one step back after each toss.	Hold the basket on your lap; they fill it.
☐ 36	Hand Shadows  from 18 mo	Just wiggle one hand shadow.	They make a shadow for you to name.	Lie back and make shadows on the ceiling.
☐ 37	Knee Bounce Ride  from 12 mo	Slow bounces only, then a cuddle.	Stop and wait: they say or sign "again."	One rhyme, one bounce, one cuddle.
☐ 38	Fill and Dump  from 12 mo	Use a wide box instead of a bowl.	Fill it with only socks, then only big blocks.	Hand them a bowl and rolled socks at your feet.

Ages 3–5

38 CARDS

☐ 01	Cushion Fort  from 3 yrs	Drape one sheet over a table.	Add a door, a window and a password sign.	Blanket over two chairs; you sit outside as the guard.
☐ 02	The Floor Is Lava  from 3 yrs	Use two big pillows only.	No landing on the same pillow twice.	Call "Lava!" from the couch; they find a pillow.
☐ 03	Pretend Café  from 3 yrs	Serve one pretend dish.	They draw a picture bill for you to pay.	Order from the couch: "One pretend pancake, please!"
☐ 04	Laundry Sort  from 3 yrs	Two piles: yours and mine.	Match all the socks, then fold the small things.	Sort a few things beside you while you fold.
☐ 05	Picture-Clue Hunt  from 4 yrs	One clue, one hiding place.	Harder hiding spots, plus a map.	Say a clue out loud: "It's cold and white." (the fridge)
☐ 06	Tape Road  from 3 yrs	One straight road and one car.	Add a bridge, a car wash and road signs.	Lay a towel on the floor as the road.
☐ 07	Simon Says  from 3 yrs	Drop the trick; just copy every move.	Add tricky moves without "Simon says."	Call the moves from the couch.
☐ 08	Feel-It Hunt  from 3 yrs	Find one soft thing and one hard thing.	Eyes closed: guess things by touch.	Find something soft in this room.
☐ 09	Story in a Bag  from 3 yrs	Name each thing and what it does.	Add a problem: "Oh no, the spoon is lost!"	Tell a story about one thing you can both see.
☐ 10	Dough Bakery  from 3 yrs	Just squish, roll and poke.	Price the cookies and count out change.	Hand over the dough at the table.
☐ 11	Animal Charades  from 3 yrs	Act out animals with their sounds.	Act what the animal is doing: a sleepy cat.	They act, you guess from the couch.
☐ 12	Rhyme Basket  from 3½ yrs	You say two words; they say "rhyme!" or "no!"	Make a silly rhyming sentence.	Rhyme words with their name from the couch.
☐ 13	Veggie Scrub  from 3 yrs	Scrub one potato together.	Hold two: which is heavier? Then check.	Hand them a potato and a dry brush to "scrub."
☐ 14	Obstacle Course  from 3 yrs	Three steps: crawl, step, hop.	Count while they go, then beat the count.	You are the obstacle: they crawl under your legs.
☐ 15	Toy Vet  from 3 yrs	Just hug and "check" each toy.	Add a waiting room and a chart for each patient.	Be the patient on the couch; they check you.

Tick a box when you've played a card. Each card's safety line applies to all its versions.







 = kind of play · bars = energy · No time to cut? Read titles aloud and let your child pick.

	CARD · STARTING AGE	MAKE IT EASIER	MAKE IT HARDER	2-MINUTE TIRED-GROWN-UP VERSION
☐ 16	Sink or Float  from 3 yrs	Drop in two things only.	Make a sinker float by putting it in a lid.	Guess "sink or float?" for things you can see.
☐ 17	Feelings Freeze  from 3 yrs	Just freeze with a happy face.	Say why your statue feels that way.	Hum from the couch; they freeze with a face.
☐ 18	Book Bridge  from 3 yrs	Lay a book flat between two piles.	Widen the gap: how many blocks can it hold?	Build a two-book bridge on the floor by you.
☐ 19	I Spy Colors  from 3 yrs	Point while you say the color.	Spy by first sound: "something starting with b."	Play from the couch.
☐ 20	Paper-Plate Masks  from 3 yrs	Color the plate as a face; no eye holes.	Make two masks and act out a short scene.	Draw a face on paper and hold it up.
☐ 21	Chalk Hop Path  from 3 yrs	Three big circles to hop between.	Number the shapes and hop in order.	One big circle: jump in, jump out.
☐ 22	Couch Puppet Show  from 3 yrs	One puppet says hello.	Add a problem and a helper to the show.	Your hand is the puppet; it asks them questions.
☐ 23	Corner Shop  from 3 yrs	Just hand over and say "thank you."	Price things 1 to 5 and count paper money.	Order from the couch; they bring it.
☐ 24	Mail Carrier  from 3 yrs	Deliver one picture.	Write names (with help) on each letter.	Ask them to deliver a "letter" to someone at home.
☐ 25	Bug Watch  from 3 yrs	Watch one bug for one minute.	Draw the bug and count its legs.	Look for bugs on a window or the step.
☐ 26	Kitchen Band  from 3 yrs	One pot, one wooden spoon.	Play loud, soft, fast or slow on your signal.	Tap a rhythm on the table; they copy.
☐ 27	Listening Walk  from 3 yrs	Stop and listen for one sound.	Draw a sound map at home.	Open a window and count the sounds.
☐ 28	Opposites Game  from 3½ yrs	Use only big and small.	Say the opposite without acting it.	Say one word; they act the opposite.
☐ 29	Tape Balance Beam  from 3 yrs	A wide line, holding hands.	Walk it with a book on your head.	Walk along the edge of a rug.
☐ 30	Color Mixing  from 3 yrs	Mix just red and yellow.	Make light and dark shades with white.	Layer two crayon colors on scrap paper.
☐ 31	Red Light, Green Light  from 3 yrs	Just stop and go.	Add silly lights: purple means hop.	Call the lights from the couch.
☐ 32	Make a Little Book  from 4 yrs	One page, one picture.	They write or copy the title.	Fold one page; they draw, you write their words.
☐ 33	Rescue Mission  from 3 yrs	Rescue one toy.	Add a pillow "boat" and no touching the floor.	The toys on your lap need rescuing.
☐ 34	Snack Patterns  from 3 yrs	Two things: cracker, banana, cracker, banana.	Make a three-part pattern.	Make a pattern with the snack on their plate.
☐ 35	Sock Ball Toss  from 3 yrs	Stand right next to the basket.	Throw with the other hand.	Hold the basket; they throw from across the room.
☐ 36	Animal Stretches  from 3 yrs	Two animals only: cat and mouse.	Hold each pose for five slow breaths.	Stretch like a cat together on the floor.
☐ 37	Flashlight Stories  from 3½ yrs	Just make shadows; no story.	They tell the story; you move the shadows.	Shine the light on the ceiling; one story line each.
☐ 38	Build a Nest  from 3½ yrs	Make a nest from a towel.	Make it strong enough to lift up.	Shape a blanket into a nest for a soft toy.

AGES 1-3

**1-3**

Ages 1-3
38 play cards

AGES 3-5

**3-5**

Ages 3-5
38 play cards

BUILD



Build & Make
Kind of play

PRETEND

**Pretend**

Pretend
Kind of play

MOVE

**Move**

Move
Kind of play

OUTDOORS

**Outdoors**

Outdoors
Kind of play

WORDS



Words & Stories

Kind of play

MUSIC



Music & Sound

Kind of play

HELPING



Kitchen & Helping

Kind of play

GAMES



Games & Puzzles

Kind of play

FAVORITES



Family favorites

The ones we play again and again

TRIED IT



Tried it!

Played at least once

SAVE FOR LATER	OUR IDEAS	
 Save for later Not today, maybe next time	 Our own ideas Cards we made up ourselves	
		





Round jar labels

Four colorways. Cut on the dashed circle and stick to the jar with clear tape or glue dots.

Label size: 3.4 in / 8.6 cm. Grown-up keeps the jar.



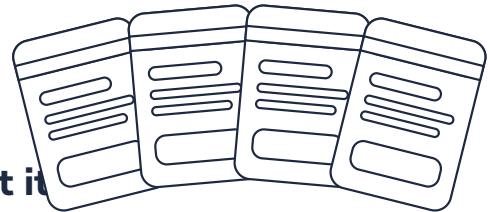
Wrap labels & energy jars

Use one big jar, or split the cards into three energy jars so your child can choose the mood first. The last two labels are blank: name a jar yourself.

I'm bored!

PLAY CARDS FOR OUR FAMILY

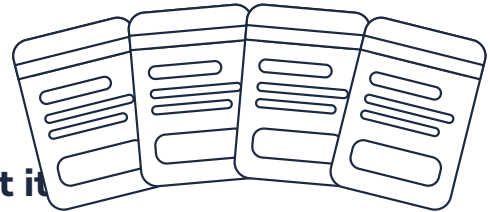
 Pull a card · Play together · Talk about it



I'm bored!

SCREEN-FREE PLAY IDEAS

 Pull a card · Play together · Talk about it



 CALM

Calm jar

Quiet, sit-down play

 MEDIUM

Medium jar

Up-and-about play

 WIGGLY

Wiggly jar

Big-body play

 LOVED

Done & loved

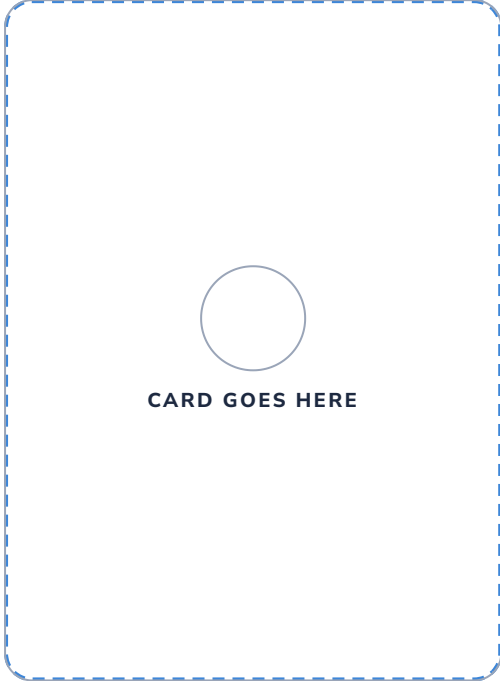
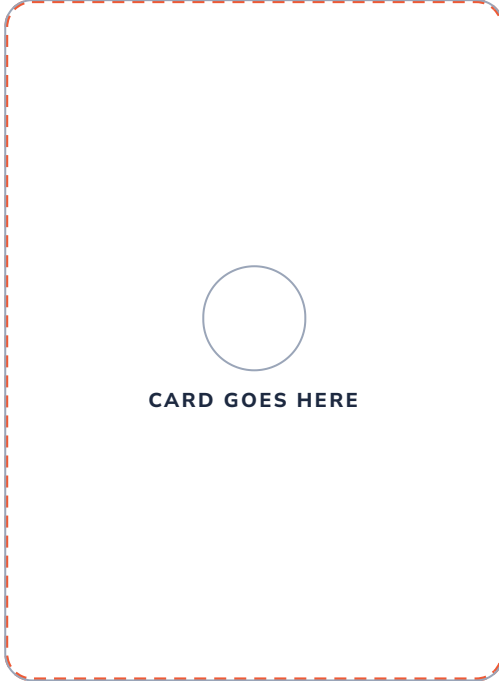
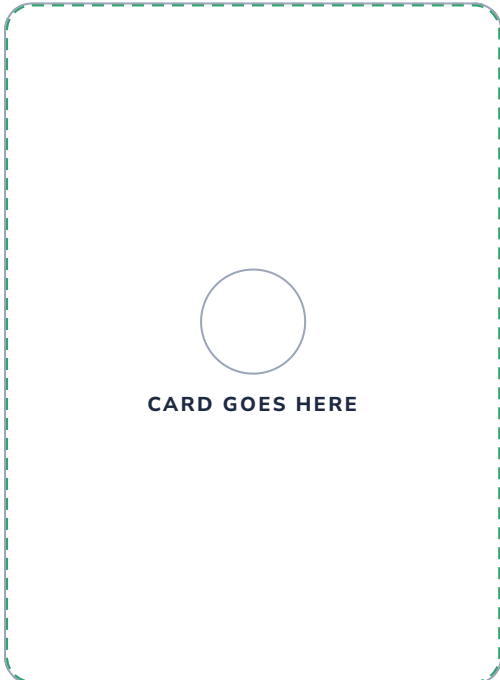
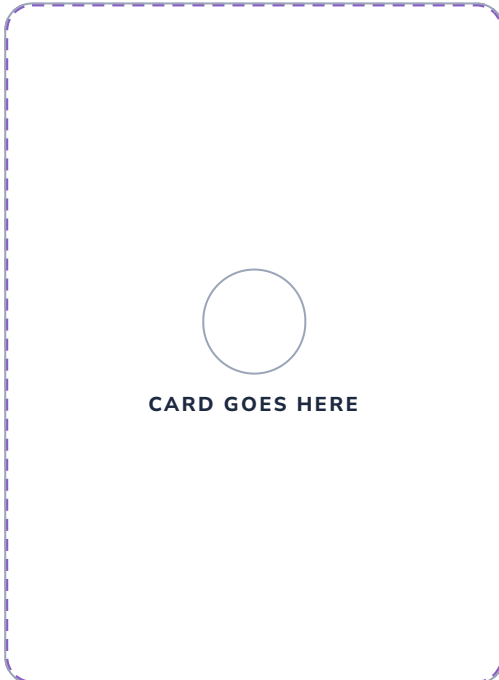
Cards we loved go here

 OUR JAR

 OUR JAR

Today's Play Menu

Put one card in each space, then let your child choose. Done? Move it to the “Done & loved” jar.

Calm pick   CARD GOES HERE	Wiggly pick   CARD GOES HERE
Together pick   CARD GOES HERE	Free choice   CARD GOES HERE

🛡️ **Hook-and-loop dots (ages 3+):** Check dots before each play; remove any that lift. **For under-3s:** no loose dots. Lay each card on top of its space, or slide the board and cards into a page protector.

Our Play Week: an example

WEEK OF

June 8

PLAYER(S)

Our two, ages 2 and 4

DAY	CARD WE PLAYED	ENERGY C · M · W	SOMETHING THEY SAID	LOVED IT?
Monday	<i>Pillow Mountain</i>	○ ○ ○	<i>"Again! Higher mountain!"</i>	☆☆☆
Tuesday	<i>Teddy Picnic</i>	○ ○ ○	<i>"Teddy wants MORE tea."</i>	☆☆☆
Wednesday	<i>Rain Band</i>	○ ○ ○	<i>"The rain is shouting now!"</i>	☆☆☆
Thursday	<i>Where's Teddy?</i>	○ ○ ○	<i>"He's hiding in my sock!"</i>	☆☆☆
Friday	<i>Animal Parade</i>	○ ○ ○	<i>"I'm a stomping duck."</i>	☆☆☆
Saturday	<i>Sand Castle</i>	○ ○ ○	<i>"A castle for the worms."</i>	☆☆☆
Sunday	<i>Reading Nest</i>	○ ○ ○	<i>"Read it with the funny voice."</i>	☆☆☆

Your turn

This page shows one way to fill it in. The blank planners come next, with Monday and Sunday starts. One card a day is plenty, and some days will be empty. That's fine too.

Our Play Week

WEEK OF

PLAYER(S)

DAY	CARD WE PLAYED	ENERGY C · M · W	SOMETHING THEY SAID	LOVED IT?
Monday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Tuesday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Wednesday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Thursday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Friday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Saturday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Sunday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆

Why write it down?

The funny things children say while they play are easy to forget. A line a day becomes a little record of your year, and a reminder of which cards to play again.

Our Play Week

WEEK OF

PLAYER(S)

DAY	CARD WE PLAYED	ENERGY C · M · W	SOMETHING THEY SAID	LOVED IT?
Sunday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Monday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Tuesday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Wednesday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Thursday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Friday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆
Saturday		○ ○ ○		☆☆☆

Why write it down?

The funny things children say while they play are easy to forget. A line a day becomes a little record of your year, and a reminder of which cards to play again.



OFFICIAL

Play Jar Star

This certificate goes to

for playing ☐ 10 ☐ 25 ☐ 50 ☐ 100 cards from the “I’m bored!” jar.

FAVORITE CARD

DATE

OUR TOP THREE CARDS

- 1 _____
- 2 _____
- 3 _____



BEST THING WE SAID WHILE WE
PLAYED

PULL A CARD. PLAY TOGETHER.



PLAY BEFORE PIXELS

Questions, answered.

My child is between two age bands.

Use both. The bands overlap on purpose, and many cards work a year or two either side. The card index gives an easier and a harder version of every card.

Do I have to play too?

For ages 1–3, yes: you are the best toy in the room. For older children, start together, then step back and be the audience. Cards marked “Can do alone” still need a grown-up at home.

Color or low-ink?

You are holding the low-ink file: white backgrounds and line art to color. The color file has the same cards in full color, with type-in blanks.

Can I print it again, or at a print shop?

Yes. Print as many copies as your household needs, at home or at a print shop. Grandparents and sitters who care for your child count as your household.

Can I give it as a gift?

Yes. Print and cut the cards, put them in a jar with one of the labels, and give the jar. The family you give it to becomes the household this license covers.

Is it in other languages?

The cards are in English. Say the talk lines in the language you know best; a sign, a point or a device tap counts as an answer.

Lost your file?

Sign in on a web browser (not the shopping app) and open Purchases in your account: your files stay there.

My child says no to every card.

Offer just two cards, or let them pull one without looking. A little boredom is fine too: it often turns into their own idea.

Which pages should I print?

Only what you need. The page guide on page 8 lists every section.

How do I type on the blanks?

Use the color file: open it in a free PDF reader that supports fill-in forms (a computer is easiest), click a box and type. In this low-ink file, the blanks are for writing by hand.

Can a teacher, center or library use it?

Not yet. This file is licensed for one household. Classroom, child-care, library and group licenses are not available yet.

My child dislikes mess or loud noise.

Skip those cards, or use the easier version: a spoon instead of hands, a towel on the pot, watching first and joining later. Every child may pass.

Is there a screen version?

No, and that's on purpose. The cards are paper so the play happens off-screen.

Download or file trouble? Download on a computer or in your phone's web browser, not in the shopping app: apps often can't save files. Still stuck? Message us through the shop.

Happy playing!

Thank you for playing with us. If a card became a family favorite, we'd love to hear which one. You can leave a review in the shop where you bought this pack.

Reviews are always optional, and honest ones help other families most.

MORE FROM PLAY BEFORE PIXELS: LOOK FOR THESE IN OUR SHOP

52 Play & Talk Cards

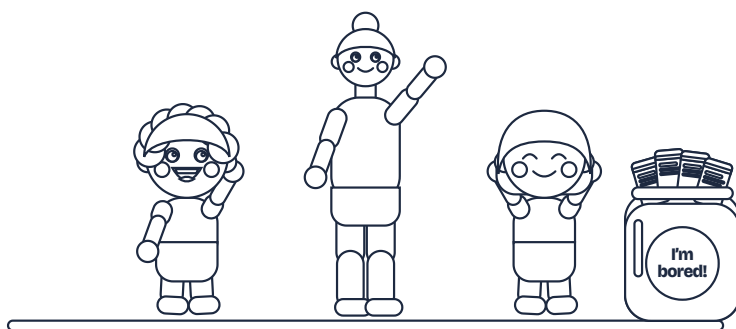
For ages 0–5: one simple play and one talk tip on every card.

Visual Routine Cards

Picture cards for mornings, bedtime and the moments in between.

100 Screen-Free Plays

Our activity book: 100 plays sorted by age, each with a talk line and a safety note.



Happy playing!

© 2026 AlphaPlay LLC. Play Before Pixels is a trade name of AlphaPlay LLC. All rights reserved. Version 1.0 · September 2026.

Print permission (personal license): you may print this file for your own household as often as you like, at home or at a print shop; grandparents and sitters who care for your child count as your household. Please don't share, resell or post the file or its pages. Classroom, child-care, library and group licenses are not available yet.

These cards are ideas for supervised play at home. They are parent education, not medical, developmental or professional advice, and they don't replace the judgment of the grown-up in charge. Follow the safety page and every card's safety line, and skip anything that doesn't suit your child.

Play Before Pixels is an independent small business. No brands, products or organizations are named or endorsed in this pack.